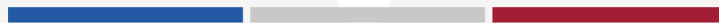




MIT SLOAN SCHOOL OF MANAGEMENT
MIT SCHWARZMAN COLLEGE OF COMPUTING



ORIENTATION MODULE UNIT 1
Media Set Video 1 Transcript

Orientation Module Unit 1 Media Set Video 1 Transcript

Introduction

PAUL MCDONAGH-SMITH: Something has changed in AI, and it's not just another capability upgrade. For the past few years, most of us have been getting comfortable with AI that responds. You prompt it, it answers. You ask it to draft, it drafts. It's reactive, it waits for you. But a new generation of AI systems doesn't wait. It plans, it uses tools, it pursues goals across multiple steps, makes decisions along the way, and here's the part that should get your attention, it acts. Not in a future scenario, now. In customer service workflows, in supply chain operations, in compliance monitoring, in code generation, and a lot more, and right now.

This is Agentic AI and it represents a fundamentally different leadership and management opportunity, because the question is no longer simply, "How do we use AI?", it's "How do we lead when AI can act autonomously?"

My name is Paul McDonagh-Smith. I'm a senior lecturer in information technology at the MIT Sloan School of Management, and I'll be your Faculty Director throughout this program.

What this program is about

MCDONAGH-SMITH: Over the three modules, we'll move through a deliberate arc. We start by exploring what Agentic AI actually is, not as a buzzword, but as a specific set of capabilities that sit at a distinct point on the AI continuum. You'll understand the shift from reactive systems that respond to prompts to proactive agents that can plan, reason, use tools, and execute multistep workflows. And critically, you'll evaluate where this creates genuine organizational value, and where the constraints still exist.

From there, we move to implementation. How do you actually operationalize agentic systems? What scaffolding turns a large language model into a reliable goal-directed agent? How do single agents become multi-agent systems? And what does orchestrating an AI workforce actually require? You'll examine real-world applied workflows, customer-facing agents, operational and supply chain agents, risk and compliance agents. This isn't theory.

It's architecture. And in our final module, we confront the scaling question, which is, in lots of ways, a governance question also. How do you move from a successful pilot to enterprise-scale deployments without losing control? What are the genuine risks? What are the security vulnerabilities, the error propagation, the accountability gaps? And how do you design safeguards that don't just mitigate risk but earn the trust that scaling demands?

What you will leave with

MCDONAGH-SMITH: You'll leave this module with a strategic deployment playbook, phased, governed, and grounded in a credible ROI narrative. Now, here's how I'll try to help you navigate this: I'll introduce you to frameworks that support your thinking; ways to evaluate agent capabilities, to map workflows, to assess risks, and design governance. You'll hear from MIT faculty working at the frontier of intelligence systems and from industry leaders who are building and deploying these systems in practice. But perhaps the most important thing I'll do is try to help you develop what I think of as an agentic instinct. The ability to look at a workflow, to look at a decision chain or a process, and see where autonomous agents could create value, where they'd create risk, and what it would actually take to deploy them responsibly. That instinct or that intuition doesn't come only from reading about Agentic AI. It comes from working through the design decisions yourself.

What will you leave with? Not a vendor evaluation or a technology shopping list. You'll leave with the ability to frame Agentic AI clearly and credibly for your organization, to identify high-value use cases, to design agent-based workflows responsibly, and to build a phased deployment strategy that connects initiative to enterprise value. In short, the capacity to lead the next phase of AI adoption with judgment, not only enthusiasm.

So here's my commitment: I'll bring rigor, curiosity, and honesty. In return, I'll ask you to bring the one thing no course can supply. Your context. Your workflows. Your real operational challenges. Your judgment about what matters most. Because the leaders who will shape how Agentic AI transforms organizations aren't those who adopt it fastest. They're the ones who deploy it most deliberately.

SPEAKER: Did you understand all the concepts covered in this video? If you'd like to review any of the content, please click on the chapter menu.